

World Geography Overview

Continents

Earth's landmass is conventionally divided into seven continents:

Continent	Area (km²)	Countries	Population	Largest Country
Asia	44,579,000	49	4.7 billion	Russia (partial)
Africa	30,370,000	54	1.4 billion	Algeria
North America	24,709,000	23	590 million	Canada
South America	17,840,000	12	435 million	Brazil
Antarctica	14,000,000	0	~5,000 (temp)	—
Europe	10,530,000	44	750 million	Russia (partial)
Australia	7,692,000	1	26 million	Australia

Major Biomes

Earth's land surface is covered by several distinct biomes, each characterised by its climate, vegetation, and wildlife:

- **Tropical Rainforest**
 - Located near the equator (Amazon, Congo, Southeast Asia)
 - High rainfall (>2,000 mm/year) and stable warm temperatures
 - Highest biodiversity of any terrestrial biome
 - Threatened by deforestation at approximately 4.7 million hectares per year
- **Savanna**
 - Tropical grasslands with scattered trees
 - Distinct wet and dry seasons
 - Found in sub-Saharan Africa, parts of Brazil (Cerrado), and northern Australia
- **Desert**
 - Receive less than 250 mm of precipitation annually
 - Cover about 33% of Earth's land surface
 - Types: hot (Sahara, Arabian), cold (Gobi, Antarctic)
- **Temperate Forest**
 - Deciduous and mixed forests of the mid-latitudes
 - Distinct four seasons; annual precipitation 750–1,500 mm
 - Covers much of Europe, eastern North America, and eastern Asia
- **Boreal Forest (Taiga)**
 - Largest terrestrial biome by area
 - Coniferous trees (spruce, fir, pine) dominate
 - Extends across Canada, Russia, and Scandinavia
- **Tundra**
 - Arctic and alpine regions above the treeline
 - Permafrost layer beneath the surface

- Very short growing season (6–10 weeks)

Major Rivers

River	Length (km)	Continent	Empties Into	Notable Feature
Nile	6,650	Africa	Mediterranean Sea	Longest river in the world
Amazon	6,400	South America	Atlantic Ocean	Greatest discharge volume
Yangtze	6,300	Asia	East China Sea	Longest river in Asia
Mississippi	6,275	North America	Gulf of Mexico	Drains 40% of contiguous USA
Yenisei	5,539	Asia	Kara Sea (Arctic Ocean)	Largest by drainage basin
Congo	4,700	Africa	Atlantic Ocean	Deepest river in the world
Danube	2,860	Europe	Black Sea	Flows through 10 countries

Mountain Ranges

The world's major mountain ranges and their highest peaks:

- **Himalayas** (Asia)
 - Contains all 14 peaks exceeding 8,000 m
 - Mount Everest: 8,849 m — highest point on Earth
 - Formed by collision of the Indian and Eurasian tectonic plates
- **Andes** (South America)
 - Longest continental mountain range: ~7,000 km
 - Aconcagua: 6,961 m — highest peak outside Asia
 - Active volcanism along much of its length
- **Rocky Mountains** (North America)
 - Extend ~4,800 km from British Columbia to New Mexico
 - Mount Elbert: 4,401 m — highest peak
 - Continental Divide runs along the crest
- **Alps** (Europe)
 - Extend ~1,200 km across eight countries
 - Mont Blanc: 4,808 m — highest peak in Western Europe
 - Origin of many major European rivers (Rhine, Rhône, Po)

Ocean Features

Feature	Location	Notable Statistic
Mariana Trench	Western Pacific	Deepest point: 10,994 m (Challenger Deep)
Great Barrier Reef	Coral Sea, Australia	Largest coral reef: ~344,000 km²
Arctic Ocean	North Pole region	Smallest and shallowest ocean
Mid-Atlantic Ridge	Atlantic Ocean floor	Longest mountain range on Earth

Gulf Stream	North Atlantic	Major ocean current warming Europe
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